

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

More killed at aid sites

Latest deaths come as Netanyahu eyes occupation of Gaza

By Wafaa Shurafa, Fatma Khaled and Natalie Melzer
Associated Press

DEIR AL-BALAH, Gaza Strip — At least 38 Palestinians were killed overnight and into Wednesday in the Gaza Strip while seeking aid from United Nations convoys and sites run by an Israeli-backed American contractor, according to local health officials. The Israeli military said it had fired warning shots when crowds approached its forces.

Another 25 people, including several women and children, were killed in Israeli airstrikes, according to local hospitals in Gaza. The military said it only targets Hamas militants.

The latest deaths came as Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu was expected to announce further military action — and possibly plans for Israel to fully reoccupy Gaza. Experts say Israel's ongoing military offensive and blockade are already pushing the territory of some 2 million Palestinians into famine. A new U.N. report said only 1.5% of Gaza's crop-land is accessible and undamaged.

Another escalation of the nearly 22-month war could put the lives of countless Palestinians and around 20 living Israeli hostages at risk, and would draw fierce opposition internationally and within Israel. Netanyahu's far-right coalition allies have long called for the war to be expanded, and for Israel to eventually take over Gaza, relocate much of its population and rebuild Jewish settlements there.

Turn to Gaza, Page 10



Mayor Brandon Johnson is flanked by Chicago Public Schools interim CEO Macquiline King, left, and Chicago Teachers Union President Stacy Davis Gates following an announcement on sustainable schools on Monday at the South Shore Cultural Center. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Mayor sought weaker CPS board voting rules

Johnson's office had denied lobbying for change, but email confirms it was 'goal'

By Nell Salzman, Alice Yin and Gregory Royal Pratt
Chicago Tribune

Despite Mayor Brandon Johnson's office saying it was not pursuing controversial changes to the Chicago Board of Education's voting procedures, his top Springfield lobbyist emailed a state official in the closing days of the spring legislative session expressing interest in a bill that would do just that.

In a May 23 message, city lobbyist John Arena wrote to a state education official that the city wanted legislation to align

the Chicago board's rules with those governing other school boards around the state. That would have included a provision to lower from a two-thirds supermajority to a simple majority the threshold the Chicago Public Schools board would need to approve certain issues — and ease the path for adopting contentious borrowing plans favored by City Hall.

"We want (to) bring a clean-up bill that addresses rights and responsibilities for school boards," Arena wrote to Dana Stoerger, Illinois State Board of Education executive

director of legal affairs, in the email obtained by the Tribune through a public records request. "The goal is to establish voting thresholds for Chicago BoE at the same level as other school boards."

In his message, Arena laid out a "non-exhaustive list of examples" that require two-thirds approval, including board bylaws and budget amendments.

Four days after that May email, Arena denied to the Tribune that he sent any

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The email



Arena

City lobbyist John Arena told a state education official that "the goal is to establish voting thresholds for Chicago

BoE at the same level as other school boards." Doing so would have made it much easier for the board to pass a contentious borrowing plan favored by Mayor Brandon Johnson.

An ear for traditions

Octogenarian busker brings bold and brassy sounds to Chinatown

By William Tong
Chicago Tribune

With a slight inhale, 81-year-old Zhen Jinling brought the short, ridged horn up to his mouth. He pursed his lips and blew into his suona — the sound part birdcall, part trumpet fanfare.

From a bench outside Chinatown's library branch, the chirpy melody and fast descending riffs of "Whipping the Horse that Transports Grain," a Chinese folk song composed in the 20th century, buzzed across the street to the nearby CTA station.

Since 2022, Zhen has spent Saturday and Sunday afternoons busking outside Wentworth and Archer avenues. Rotating between several instruments, Zhen shares a taste of traditional Chinese music with locals and visitors alike.

"(I) entertain the community, entertain myself," Zhen said last



Busker Zhen Jinling, left, thanks a passerby for giving him money while he plays traditional Chinese folk music on the suona, a horn instrument, in Chinatown on July 27 in Chicago. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

month in Mandarin Chinese.

Zhen, originally from Taishan in Guangdong province, said he came to the U.S. at least 15 years ago. He often played in Chinese opera and folk music companies in Chicago, New York and other areas, focusing on Cantonese opera music, he said.

"Private opera companies don't have much money," he said. "I've spent my life learning music — giving myself to it."

Zhen set down his suona and put his erhu, a type of Chinese violin, in his lap. As he drew the bow along the upright strings, a

mellower tone floated into the air. It's nowhere near as loud as the suona, but turned heads nonetheless.

A young man and woman stopped to watch Zhen play.

"May I see it?" The woman asked Zhen in English after he paused, gesturing to the erhu.

He scooted over to let her sit down and handed her the instrument. Zhen guided her right hand as she pulled the bow back and forth, the sound shifting from an initial croak to something

Turn to Busker, Page 2

After bomb threat, Pritzker vows to protect Texas Dems

By Dan Petrella, Olivia Olander and Jeremy Gorner
Chicago Tribune

Gov. JB Pritzker emphasized his administration was closely coordinating with state and even local law enforcement to protect Texas House Democrats who fled to Illinois to stop a Republican congressional remap, especially after a bomb threat caused the lawmakers to be evacuated Wednesday morning from their suburban hotel.

Pritzker's remarks at the Illinois State Fairgrounds in Springfield came hours after the bomb threat at a secure hotel in west suburban St. Charles forced the evacuation of 400 guests, including dozens of Texas House

Democrats who left their state to stop the Republican-controlled state legislature from redrawing congressional district boundaries to the GOP's advantage ahead of next year's midterm election.

Even before the bomb threat, since the lawmakers arrived in Illinois, New York and Massachusetts on Sunday, they have faced Republican threats of being arrested, charged and removed from office all while Pritzker has vowed to keep those lawmakers who are in Illinois safe.

"We've had to react from a law enforcement perspective here in the state by calling our state police, local law enforcement, making sure that they're protecting the people who are

Turn to Texas, Page 5

'WE STUCK TOGETHER': Current and former Indiana House Democrats recalled the immediate benefit and long-term impact of fleeing the state to delay legislation over a decade ago as Texas Democrats remained in Chicago to delay a special session to redraw congressional maps. **Chicagoland, Page 5**

CLASH SPURS QUESTIONS: Other states are waiting to see what happens with the fallout from Texas' unusual move before pursuing their own redistricting plans. **Nation & World in Business, Page 5**

Innocence quest delayed

Months after a court reversed the conviction of Kevin Jackson, his quest for an exoneration in the form of a certificate of innocence has been delayed after the case was reassigned to outside prosecutors. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

An on-court reinvention



The Sky's Rachel Banham has spent her WNBA career in a constant state of redefinition. Now, unexpectedly pushed into the starting point guard role, she's having her best season as a professional. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 90 Low 74

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 28

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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